the execution to Kashmiris in the most dramatic manner possible—by putting an entire nation under a clampdown, uniting Kashmiris simultaneously in grief, mourning and misery. Late letters, the indecency of not returning the body, the fact of not allowing his family members to meet him one last time, the February 9th of the execution (almost coinciding with Maqbool Bhat's death anniversary on 11 February, another Kashmiri hanged in the same prison twenty-nine years ago), all of it was made very public. Afzal's execution was meant to be a public event in India. Only in this public and brazen manner of execution, and not in any other way, could the 'national conscience' have been satisfied.

It was never a matter of justice but about the display of what Indian state officials call 'national will'—which is often what the state projects as the collective decision of the nation. The Indian nation can't be tough if the execution followed a procedure. National will is not displayed in following documents like the Constitution or international human rights norms; it is, rather, displayed in the ability to transcend such obstacles to sovereign action. TADA, POTA, AFSPA, etc. are all displays of such national will. Mohammad Afzal Guru's execution in this public and dramatic way is how sovereignty exercises itself—through an absolute, and extralegal, control over how, why, what, where and when of dispensing death. Sovereignty is above law and civility.

Many pro-India Kashmiri politicians, including a few unaffiliated commentators, are upset about the manner of hanging. They complain that Kashmiri sensitivities were not taken into account. It is surprising that at a time which could very well mark the most unapologetic and barefaced policy shift in India's efforts in Kashmir—forcing a resolution through demographic change (settlements and a possible annihilation)—these commentators expect the Indian state to worry about Kashmiri 'sensitivities'. Invoking sensitivities in the face of the state's open disregard for Kashmiri lives de- radicalizes the political understanding of the event in Kashmir. It softens the image of the state, even though the state has clearly declared that it will not be soft on Kashmiris. It is possible that by 'sensitivity' Kashmir's pro-India politicians just mean their own electoral calculations.

Instead of being a question of sentiments or conscience, the execution was a deeply political event. Political events bring to the fore fundamental contradictions that underlie political conflicts. Such events remove everyday obfuscations that blur the nature of the relationship between the contestants in